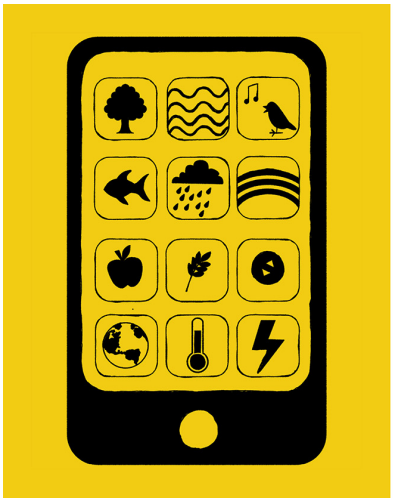


NATURAL ECOSYSTEMS AND THEIR SPECIES HELP SUSTAIN AND FULFILL HUMAN LIFE

NATURE'S CONTRIBUTIONS TO PEOPLE

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Gretchen Daily (1964–)

BEFORE

c.400 BCE Greek philosopher Plato is aware of the human impact on nature, noting that deforestation can cause soil to erode and springs to run dry.

1973 German statistician and economist E.F. Schumacher coins the term "natural capital" in his book *Small is Beautiful*.

AFTER

1998 The UN Environment program, NASA, and the World Bank release a study on how protecting the planet serves human needs.

2008 A study at the University of California, Berkeley, shows that ecological destruction by the world's richest countries means they owe the world's poorest countries more than the developing world's debt.

Nature's contributions to people are the services and disservices provided by nature that underpin human health and well-being. The benefits nature provides to humans can also be termed "ecosystem services," but more recently, the term "nature's contributions to people (NCP)" is used,